

Sanibha App Creation Playbook & Checklist

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How to use this playbook

Every app passes the same twelve stages in order, and a stage is done only when every box is ticked and the founder has signed it off. Duplicate this doc once per app so progress never mixes between apps.

1. Stage 0: Idea validation and go/no-go
2. Stage 1: Product and UX spec
3. Stage 2: In-app standards
4. Stage 3: Engineering and architecture
5. Stage 4: Analytics, attribution and measurement
6. Stage 5: Monetization and pricing
7. Stage 6: Legal and compliance
8. Stage 7: App Store submission and ASO
9. Stage 8: Marketing and growth
10. Stage 9: Launch
11. Stage 10: Post-launch operations
12. Stage 11: Finance and company operations

Rules for reading the checklists:

- **[GATE]** marks an item that blocks release until it is ticked.
- **[VERIFY]** marks an item whose rules change or depend on your situation. Check it against current Apple/Meta documentation, or with a lawyer or chartered accountant, before relying on it.
- Stages 1 to 6 can overlap. Nothing is submitted to Apple until Stages 0 to 7 are signed off.
- This is a shared spec, not shared code. Each app keeps its own codebase and backend, and every app must satisfy every **[GATE]** item here.
- Interns own the build items for their assigned apps. The founder owns validation, legal sign-off, pricing, marketing spend and the go/no-go call.

App	Builder	Status as of 5 Oct 2026
Fax	Kushagra	Mockup and handover spec done; build paused
Baby tracker	Kushagra	Mockup, spec and privacy requirements done; build paused
Sleep tracker	Kushagra	Not started
Universal TV remote	Kushagra	Not started
Storage cleaner	Ganesh	Not started
Calorie counter	Ganesh	Not started
Plant identifier	Ganesh	Not started
Habit tracker	Ganesh	Not started
AI resume builder	Harshil	Not started
Recipe importer	Harshil	Not started
Immigration case tracker	Harshil	Not started
Document scanner / PDF toolkit	Harshil	Not started

Version log: v0.1, 5 Oct 2026, first draft. Phase 0 internal tools (store-listing watcher, paywall tracker, review-mining agent, ad-tracking digest, design-system auditor, onboarding benchmarker) are due before any app coding starts.

Stage 0: Idea validation and go/no-go

An app enters the build queue only if it clears a written evidence bar and has its kill criteria fixed, in numbers, before the first line of code.

Evidence bar

- ☐ [GATE] At least 3 named competitors with revenue from a tool (Appfigures, Sensor Tower) or a company disclosure, each with the date of the figure.
- ☐ Top-grossing competitor's reviews pulled: the 10 most common complaints ranked, plus the latest 300 reviews. Lifetime ratings hide current decline.

- ☐ Incumbent trust gap written in one sentence (forced paywall, billing surprise, data loss, support black hole). This is the positioning wedge.
- ☐ Acquisition cost for the niche found and labeled **measured** or **estimate**. Every model must carry that label.
- ☐ Keyword demand checked in Apple Search Ads popularity scores and Google Keyword Planner (both free).
- ☐ Free native alternative checked: does iOS already ship this for free (Measure, Files, Authenticator)? If yes, flag the category as weak.
- ☐ Platform-risk check: category-wide fake reviews, Apple review-removal enforcement, scam competitors on rotating domains.
- ☐ Data-licensing dependency checked (flight data and similar vendor feeds are a business-development problem, not a coding one).
- ☐ Build difficulty classed as assemble-from-parts or real accuracy ceiling (background GPS, computer vision, sensor tuning).
- ☐ [GATE] Legal risk classed low, medium or high. Health data, children's data, precise location, recording consent and money movement are high and need a lawyer before building.

Scoring and economics

- ☐ Scored in the 15-factor matrix under both weightings, with the lens that decided the ranking written down.
- ☐ One-page unit-economics model: CPI, install-to-trial, trial-to-paid, price, expected paying months, LTV:CAC, payback and test budget as a share of the reserve.
- ☐ Plan type chosen deliberately. Weekly plans carry about 74% of Utilities revenue; a one-time price below the CPI cannot support paid acquisition.
- ☐ Highest CPI at which LTV:CAC reaches 1x and 3x calculated. If the achievable CPI sits above the 1x level, stop.

Kill and scale criteria (set before building)

These are starting proposals. The founder confirms or changes each number and records it per app.

Checkpoint	Metric	Starting proposal
Week 2 after launch	Day-7 retention	Kill if below half the category leader's benchmark

Checkpoint	Metric	Starting proposal
Weeks 4 to 6	Blended LTV:CAC (modeled)	Scale at 3:1 or better; one more creative or targeting iteration if below; kill if still below
Any time	Share of test budget	No single app above 15% of the total before it passes a gate
Two consecutive checkpoints	Not failing, not clearing the scale gate	Kill regardless of narrative

- ☐ [GATE] Per-app kill and scale numbers written and dated.
- ☐ [GATE] Founder go/no-go recorded with the date.

Stage 1: Product and UX spec

A spec is done when someone who never saw the research can build the app from it and the founder can test the result against an approved mockup. Mockups only click through screens; they save no data, so the spec must state persistence rules in words.

Scope

- ☐ [GATE] Core job written in one sentence.
- ☐ [GATE] An explicit out-of-scope list. The narrow-scope winners we studied (ReciMe, Genius Scan) grew by cutting features, not adding them.
- ☐ Free versus paid line defined. Previously entered user data is never locked by a downgrade or lapse; caps apply only going forward.
- ☐ First value moment defined (first fax sent, first meal logged, first scan exported). Paywall timing, the ATT pre-prompt and the review prompt all key off it.

Screens and states

- ☐ Every screen listed with its empty, loading, error, offline, permission-denied, payment-failed and limit-reached states.
- ☐ Inline validation for every input, written as: what happened, then what to do. No "Error:" prefix. Use the provider's reason codes where they exist (for example a fax failure reason mapped to a specific message).
- ☐ [GATE] No hardcoded times, dates, names or sample entries outside a true first-run empty state. Dates and times come from the device clock and saved records.

- ☐ Edge cases listed: midnight-crossing entries, time zone and daylight-saving changes, a wrong device clock, large files, app killed mid-action, offline queue, restore on a new device, duplicate invites, owner versus collaborator rights.
- ☐ Permissions requested in context, with a plain explanation first. The app still works in a reduced mode if the user declines.

Design and copy

- ☐ Built on SanibhaDesignKit tokens, with the app's own color, icon and voice so siblings do not look identical.
- ☐ Tap targets at least 44 by 44 points, Dynamic Type supported, VoiceOver labels on every control, sufficient color contrast, Reduce Motion respected, dark mode checked.
- ☐ English (US) only for v1, but all strings in a string catalog from day one so adding languages is cheap.
- ☐ Prices and billing terms written in plain language, with no dark patterns (no hidden cheaper plan, no fake buttons, no hard-to-find decline).

Sign-off

- ☐ [GATE] Clickable mockup approved by the founder, including the validation and failure paths, not only the happy path.
- ☐ [GATE] Handover doc assembled in the standard format: mockup link, setup checklist, full spec, out of scope, billing transparency block, next steps.

Stage 2: In-app standards

These behaviors are identical in every app. They come from the competitor failures we found most often: billing surprises, forced paywalls, data loss and silent failures.

Onboarding and accounts

- ☐ Show value before asking for sign-up or payment wherever the product allows it.
- ☐ [GATE] If the app lets users create an account, it offers in-app account deletion (Apple requires this). [VERIFY] the current wording of Guideline 5.1.1.
- ☐ [GATE] If any third-party social login is offered, check whether Sign in with Apple or an equivalent privacy-preserving login is also required. [VERIFY] Guideline 4.8.
- ☐ User identity stays siloed per app. Cross-app linking happens only if the user opts in.
- ☐ Data export available to every user, including on the free tier.

Paywall and billing transparency

- ☐ [GATE] Paywall shows the price, billing period, trial length and auto-renewal terms before the purchase button, with working links to Terms and Privacy, and a Restore Purchases control. [VERIFY] against Guideline 3.1.2.
- ☐ [GATE] Prices come from StoreKit's localized product price, never hardcoded, so every screen matches and currencies are right.
- ☐ [GATE] No trial converts without a reminder at least 24 hours before the charge (in-app plus a local notification the user can see).
- ☐ No fake close buttons, hidden cheaper plans, pre-selected expensive plans or hard-to-find decline options.
- ☐ Plain-language refund and cancellation policy on the pricing screen.
- ☐ Failed-payment banner on the account screen with an Update payment action. A failed charge never silently removes access.

Cancellation (3 steps)

- ☐ [GATE] Step 1: Cancel is visible on the account screen at the same weight as other actions. Step 2: a confirmation stating exactly what happens and the end date, with at most one retention offer that is no more prominent than "No thanks, cancel anyway". Step 3: final confirm. Labels are identical across all three screens.
- ☐ [GATE] Apple in-app subscriptions cannot be cancelled by the app itself. Our earlier specs said "cancel immediately in the billing system", which applies to web billing only. For Apple subscriptions, step 3 opens Apple's manage-subscriptions screen and the app confirms the user's end date. [VERIFY] the current StoreKit manage-subscriptions call.
- ☐ [VERIFY] Retention offers on Apple subscriptions go through Apple's promotional or win-back offer mechanisms, not a custom discount.

Tracking permission (ATT)

- ☐ [GATE] The ATT system prompt appears only after the app's first value moment, never at launch.
- ☐ [GATE] A full-screen pre-prompt comes first. It educates in one sentence tied to a benefit already delivered and never pressures or hides the decline path. Apple allows one system prompt per install.
- ☐ Founder approves the pre-prompt copy before launch. Industry opt-in is only 15 to 35 percent, so budget models assume the low end.

Notifications and reviews

- ☐ Ask for notification permission only after the user sets up something that needs it (a reminder, a streak), with a one-line reason first.
- ☐ Notification content is useful and rare. Quiet delivery (provisional authorization) is considered for the first prompt.
- ☐ [GATE] Ratings are requested only through Apple's system review prompt, after the first value moment, and never routed by sentiment. Apple disallows custom review prompts, and the shared review-gate component in the design kit must not send unhappy users away from the App Store. [VERIFY] Guideline 5.6.1 before building it.
- ☐ No incentives for reviews, no asking support contacts to post only positive public reviews.

Reliability and data

- ☐ [GATE] Every save writes to durable storage before the UI shows success, and every list renders from saved data.
- ☐ Offline entries queue locally and sync later, with conflict handling when two devices or caregivers edit the same record.
- ☐ Every failure shows a specific, recoverable message and a retry. Nothing fails silently.
- ☐ An in-app Help or Contact entry exists and matches the support URL in App Store Connect.

Stage 3: Engineering and architecture

All code is AI-written from this playbook plus the app's own spec, so the controls below exist to catch what generated code gets quietly wrong: placeholders, missing error paths, exposed secrets and unbuilt deletion.

Decisions to record

- ☐ [GATE] Native iOS only. The framework (Swift/SwiftUI or React Native) is still undecided. The founder records the choice here once made, with the reason.
- ☐ One private repository per app. No shared code or shared backend between apps. Only the Crashlytics/Analytics Firebase project is shared.
- ☐ The app's spec and the prompts used to generate it live in the repo (for example a docs folder), so any engineer can regenerate or continue the work if the original builder leaves.
- ☐ Backend per app (Firebase or Supabase), hosted in a US region.

Code process

- ☐ Protected main branch. Every change goes through a pull request reviewed by someone other than its author.
- ☐ Generated code is read, not only run. The review checks for hardcoded data, missing error handling, secrets in code and unbuilt deletion or export.
- ☐ Automated build on every pull request. Version numbers follow a fixed scheme and each release has a short changelog.
- ☐ Dependencies tracked and updated, with automated vulnerability alerts switched on.

Secrets and security

- ☐ [GATE] No API key, token or credential in the app binary or in the repo. Anything shipped in the app can be extracted, so third-party keys (fax, AI, payments) stay on the backend.
- ☐ [GATE] Secret scanning on every commit. Separate development and production keys. Any key that appears in a chat, ticket or screenshot is treated as leaked and rotated the same day.
- ☐ [GATE] Database access rules (Firestore rules or Supabase row-level security) written and tested so one user cannot read another's data. Test with two accounts.
- ☐ Tokens in the Keychain. Sensitive data, especially photos and anything about children, encrypted at rest.
- ☐ Webhook endpoints verify the sender's signature, handle repeats safely and return success quickly.

Payments (technical)

- ☐ StoreKit sandbox and test accounts used for every purchase path: subscribe, trial, renew, cancel, refund, billing retry, restore.
- ☐ Entitlements are kept in sync from Apple's server notifications, not only from the device. [VERIFY] the current App Store Server API and notification versions.
- ☐ Decide whether to use a subscription or paywall service (RevenueCat, Superwall or none) before building the paywall, because it changes the integration. The founder records the choice.

Testing

- ☐ Written manual test script per app covering every screen and failure state in the spec.
- ☐ Tested on a real iPhone, on the oldest iOS version the app supports, on the smallest supported screen, with low-power mode, airplane mode, a throttled network, a killed app mid-action and a time zone change.

- ☐ TestFlight beta with at least 5 outside testers before submission.
- ☐ For apps with background work (mileage, sleep), a standalone feasibility spike is done and reviewed before the app is committed to.

Operations

- ☐ Crash reporting live before the first TestFlight build.
- ☐ Backups switched on for the database and one restore actually tested. The deletion job from Stage 6 is built and tested.
- ☐ Usage-based costs (AI calls, fax pages, storage) have spend alerts and hard caps so one bug cannot create a surprise bill.
- ☐ Alerts on payment-webhook and third-party API failures.
- ☐ SDK inventory table kept current: SDK, purpose, data accessed, destination, last reviewed. No SDK is added without a review. [VERIFY] whether each SDK needs an Apple privacy manifest.

Stage 4: Analytics, attribution and measurement

The business thesis is LTV/CAC, so every app ships with the events and dashboards needed to compute it from day one. Adding tracking after launch means the first weeks of spend cannot be read.

Event plan (minimum for every app)

Event	Fires when	Used for
first_open	First launch after install	Installs, cohort start
onboarding_complete	User finishes onboarding	Upper-funnel signal for ad optimization
first_value	App's defined first value moment	Activation rate, ATT and review timing
paywall_viewed	Paywall shown, with placement	Paywall conversion by placement
trial_started	Trial begins, with plan type	Install-to-trial rate
subscription_started	Paid plan begins, with plan, price, currency	Conversion event sent to ad platforms

Event	Fires when	Used for
subscription_renewed / cancelled / refunded	Apple server notification	Retention, LTV, refund rate
att_result	User answers the ATT prompt	Opt-in rate per app
push_permission_result	User answers the notification prompt	Reminder reach
d1 / d7 / d30 return	Derived from sessions	Retention

Attribution and ad-platform signals

- ☐ [GATE] Apple Search Ads attribution wired in. It does not depend on the ATT prompt, so it is the cleanest read on paid installs.
- ☐ Decision recorded: use a mobile measurement partner (AppsFlyer, Adjust, Singular) or the platforms' own SDKs. [VERIFY] the current iOS measurement setup for Meta app campaigns, including SKAdNetwork handling.
- ☐ Subscription purchase events reach Meta with value and currency, and a test purchase is seen in Events Manager before spend starts.
- ☐ A bridge event (trial start or onboarding complete) is ready to optimize on while purchase volume is below about 50 per ad set per week.
- ☐ SKAdNetwork conversion-value mapping drafted per app. [VERIFY] the current version's rules.
- ☐ Events never carry names, emails or free text. What is collected matches the App Privacy labels and the privacy policy.

Definitions (write them once, use them everywhere)

- ☐ [GATE] LTV is calculated on net proceeds after Apple's commission, not on the shelf price. Earlier models in this project used gross prices and overstate LTV. [VERIFY] the current commission rates and Small Business Program terms.
- ☐ CAC is cost per paying subscriber, not cost per install. LTV:CAC and payback period are computed per plan type.
- ☐ Every figure in a model is labeled measured or estimate.

Dashboards and cadence

- ☐ One dashboard per app: installs and cost by channel, install-to-trial, trial-to-paid, paywall conversion by placement, d1/d7/d30 retention, first-renewal rate, refund rate, proceeds.
- ☐ Test devices and team accounts excluded from reporting. All times in UTC.
- ☐ Daily review for the first 14 days after launch, weekly after that, with a one-page KPI sheet per app.
- ☐ Experiment log: every price, paywall and creative test gets a hypothesis, start and end dates, and a result. Do not change an Apple Search Ads Target CPA within two weeks of a change, and do not edit a Meta ad set during its learning phase.
- ☐ Competitor feeds from the Phase 0 tools (store-listing watcher, paywall tracker, review mining, ad tracking) reviewed weekly.

Stage 5: Monetization and pricing

Pick the model from the category's own benchmark, then test it. Trials lift lifetime value in some App Store categories and cut it in others.

App Store category	Effect of a free trial on LTV (Adapty 2026)	Implication
Utilities	+85% LTV premium, the largest of any category; highest first-renewal retention (58%)	Trial plus weekly plan is the default to test
Health & Fitness	+64% LTV premium; best trial-to-paid (35%) but lowest first-renewal retention (30%)	Trials work, but plan for fast churn
Education	+50% LTV premium	Trials work; expect exam-season spikes
Lifestyle	-21% LTV	Test a direct-purchase paywall without a trial
Productivity, Graphics & Design	Trials reduce LTV versus direct buyers	Test a direct-purchase paywall without a trial

- ☐ [GATE] The App Store category chosen for the app is confirmed against this table, because it decides which benchmark applies.

- ☐ Plan types chosen per app. In one dataset weekly plans had a 9.8% install-to-trial rate against 0.3% for monthly and 1.8% for annual. [VERIFY] with your own data.

Setup in App Store Connect

- ☐ [GATE] Paid Apps Agreement accepted, with banking and tax forms complete. Nothing can be sold until this is done.
- ☐ Subscription group, product IDs, localized names and descriptions, and price points set for the US first.
- ☐ Introductory offer configured and the paywall screenshot attached for review.
- ☐ Every purchase path tested in the sandbox before submission (Stage 3).

Pricing rules

- ☐ [GATE] One price shown everywhere it appears: App Store listing, paywall, website and ads.
- ☐ [GATE] Existing payers are grandfathered whenever pricing or packaging changes. A one-time purchaser is never converted into a subscriber, and previously included features are never moved behind a higher tier. This is the most repeated complaint across the competitors we studied.
- ☐ Free tier gives one complete, usable output, not a watermarked demo or a locked export.
- ☐ Lifetime plans only if the founder explicitly approves, and with no recurring paywall prompts afterwards.
- ☐ Paywall placement tested at the first value moment against an immediate paywall. One variable per test, with a written hypothesis.
- ☐ Refund rate tracked. Apple processes refunds, and the app handles the refund notification correctly.
- ☐ [VERIFY] Whether US external purchase links or web checkout are currently allowed without penalty. Do not plan around them until confirmed. In the one dataset found, web paywalls converted at 1.10% against 1.60% in-app and gave lower 12-month LTV even after saving the store fee.
- ☐ [VERIFY] Apple's current commission tiers and Small Business Program eligibility, and use net proceeds in every model.

Stage 6: Legal and compliance

This is a working checklist, not legal advice. Items marked [VERIFY] need a US privacy lawyer or an Indian chartered accountant before launch. One lawyer pass over all 12 apps' policies is cheaper than 12 separate ones, because the underlying data practices are similar.

Company, accounts and contracts

- ☐ [GATE] Sanibha Pvt. Ltd. fully incorporated (it was still in process on 29 Sep 2026), with a company bank account.
- ☐ [GATE] Apple Developer Program organization account enrolled in the company's name. This needs a D-U-N-S number, which can take weeks, so request it early. [VERIFY] current requirements.
- ☐ At least two named admins on the Apple account, a company-domain email, two-factor authentication on, and no shared personal Apple IDs.
- ☐ One account holding all 12 apps means one termination hits all of them. Keep every submission clean, and [VERIFY] Apple's rules before splitting apps across accounts.
- ☐ [GATE] Every contributor signs an IP-assignment and confidentiality agreement before pushing code. Formal intern offer letters were pending incorporation. [VERIFY] wording with a lawyer.
- ☐ [VERIFY] Tax forms in App Store Connect for a foreign entity, and the Indian GST, FEMA and income-tax treatment of foreign-currency receipts, with a chartered accountant.

Documents every app needs

- ☐ [GATE] App-specific privacy policy (not a generic template) linked in the app and in App Store Connect.
- ☐ [GATE] Terms of Use or EULA linked from the paywall.
- ☐ Support URL and support email on the company domain, plus a marketing URL.
- ☐ Written data-retention policy and a built, tested account-deletion job.
- ☐ [GATE] App Privacy labels answered from the actual SDK and data inventory (Stage 3), not from memory. [VERIFY] whether each SDK needs a privacy manifest.
- ☐ Landing pages that use ad pixels get a consent or opt-out mechanism where state privacy law requires it. [VERIFY]

Privacy and sector rules

- ☐ State privacy laws (California's CCPA/CPRA and the growing list of others) assessed per app, with a 30-day internal target for deletion and access requests.
- ☐ [VERIFY] Whether the FTC Health Breach Notification Rule and state consumer-health-data laws (for example Washington's) apply to calorie, sleep, baby and similar trackers. HIPAA likely does not apply to consumer apps with no healthcare-provider tie-in.
- ☐ Baby tracker: COPPA analysis says a parent-operated app marketed to adults is not automatically covered. Still required: retention policy, SDK audit, no child data to ad networks, encryption of photos, and lawyer review before launch (see the BabyLog privacy requirements doc).
- ☐ Location apps (mileage): state location-data rules reviewed, with a clear purpose string and minimal retention.
- ☐ Any feature that records audio or calls needs an all-party-consent review before it is built. Twelve US states require all-party consent.
- ☐ Health and nutrition screens carry plain disclaimers (growth percentiles and calorie figures are references, not medical advice), and ads make no diagnostic or unsubstantiated accuracy claims.

Subscriptions and advertising law

- ☐ [VERIFY] Federal ROSCA and state automatic-renewal laws (California's is strict). Our billing rules in Stage 2 are meant to exceed them.
- ☐ Paid creators and affiliates disclose the relationship. No fake or incentivized reviews, which the FTC now treats as an enforcement priority. [VERIFY]

Names and intellectual property

- ☐ [GATE] App name cleared: USPTO search, domain, App Store name search, and an attorney's opinion for finalists. Nearly every obvious short name we tried already existed in the same category, and a shared prefix across apps creates one linked point of dispute.
- ☐ No competitor names or trademarks in the title, subtitle or keywords.
- ☐ Licenses recorded for icons, fonts, sounds, stock images, AI-generated assets and open-source packages. Avoid copyleft licenses in the app binary. [VERIFY]
- ☐ Terms of any data or API source (weather, maps, AI, fax) checked for commercial and redistribution use.

Submission-time compliance

- ☐ Age-rating questionnaire answered honestly. [VERIFY] Apple's current rating system.

- ☐ Export-compliance (encryption) question in App Store Connect answered. [VERIFY]
- ☐ Territories set deliberately. US only for launch.

Incidents

- ☐ One-page breach and incident plan: who decides, who contacts the lawyer, which keys to rotate, how users are told. [VERIFY] state notification deadlines.

Stage 7: App Store submission and ASO

A rejection costs days or weeks, and repeated sloppy submissions can flag the whole developer account that all 12 apps depend on. Submit only a genuine, working build.

Listing assets

- ☐ Name, subtitle, keyword field, description, promotional text, category and what's-new text written. Keywords come from Apple Search Ads popularity scores and the Phase 0 store-listing watcher, with no competitor names and no keyword stuffing.
- ☐ Screenshots in the currently required iPhone sizes, showing the real UI. The first three carry the pitch. [VERIFY] required sizes in App Store Connect.
- ☐ Optional preview video under 30 seconds.
- ☐ Support URL, marketing URL and privacy policy URL live and working.
- ☐ Custom Product Pages and Product Page Optimization tests planned for after launch, so ads and ASO can test different pitches.

Submission package

- ☐ [GATE] Reviewer notes explain how to reach every feature, including the paywall, and a working demo account is supplied if login is required.
- ☐ [GATE] A clear, specific purpose string for every permission (camera, photos, location, microphone, tracking, notifications).
- ☐ [GATE] In-app purchases created and submitted with the first app version, and tested in the sandbox.
- ☐ TestFlight internal and external testing finished with no open crash or data-loss bugs.
- ☐ Release set to manual so launch timing is controlled. [VERIFY] phased-release options for updates.

Guidelines most likely to bite this portfolio

- ☐ [GATE] App completeness (Guideline 2.1): no placeholders, dead links, crashes or half-built screens. Never submit a deliberately thin app to get ahead in the queue.

- ☐ [GATE] Spam and duplicate apps (Guideline 4.3): 12 apps from one developer that look like one template in different colors invite rejection. Each app needs a distinct UX, content and brand. [VERIFY] Guidelines 4.2.6 and 4.3.
- ☐ In-app purchase rules (Guideline 3.1.1): digital features sold through Apple IAP, and no steering users to cheaper outside prices.
- ☐ Privacy (Guideline 5.1): account deletion, honest privacy labels, ATT used correctly.
- ☐ Health, fitness and medical claims (Guideline 1.4): accuracy claims are supportable and disclaimers are present.

Process

- ☐ Create the App Store Connect record early to reserve the name. This is not a submission.
- ☐ Plan for a long first review. The founder has seen 2 to 3 months reported, while Apple's own published figures are usually much shorter. [VERIFY] current times. Submit the strongest candidate early and keep improving it while it waits.
- ☐ Rejection playbook: read the exact guideline cited, reply in the Resolution Center with specifics, fix what is valid, appeal through the App Review Board only for a genuine disagreement, and keep a log. Do not resubmit the same binary repeatedly.
- ☐ After approval: download from the live App Store, confirm prices and in-app purchases are live, and check that analytics and attribution fire on a real install.
- ☐ Update cadence set. Codeway, which holds a \$90M-a-year app, ships roughly every 13 days, and competitors that stopped shipping declined shortly after.

Stage 8: Marketing and growth

The thesis is that execution on acquisition beats product novelty, so each app needs creative, accounts and budgets ready before the build finishes. Several lead times (Meta account approval, Apple review) are longer than the build itself.

Platform mechanics that set the budget

Channel	What the algorithm needs	Budget rule	Common mistake
Meta	About 50 purchase events per ad set in 7 days to leave the learning phase; 100 or more per week for broad targeting to work well	Weekly minimum = 50 x cost per purchase (a \$15 cost per purchase means about \$750 per week per ad set)	Spreading 12 apps thin so every ad set sits in Learning Limited
Meta, subscription purchase	Counts only purchases attributed to a Meta ad click or view; organic purchases cannot be added	The 10-event threshold applies to App Install campaigns, not App Event campaigns, so plan for 50	Assuming organic sales can fill the gap
Apple Search Ads	Around 5 conversions per day and a two-week runway; no fixed 50-event rule	Hold Target CPA steady for two weeks, because changing it resets learning	Judging results after a few days
Apple Search Ads, discovery	Keywords graduate to exact match at about 10 conversions	Run discovery campaigns to mine terms	Skipping discovery and guessing keywords

- ☐ [GATE] Marketing runs on 2 to 3 apps at a time. Launching spend on all 12 at once is the most avoidable mistake.
- ☐ Validate first on Apple Search Ads (cleaner attribution, no ATT dependency), and use Meta mainly for creative testing until volume supports learning.
- ☐ No app takes more than 15% of the total test budget before it passes a gate in Stage 0.
- ☐ Plan launches around seasonality: tax season for mileage, exam periods for study apps, January for habit and calorie apps, spring for plants. Ad costs usually rise in Q4. [VERIFY] with your own data.

Accounts and lead times

- ☐ [GATE] Meta Business account created, business verified and ad account submitted for approval at least 5 weeks before launch. Approval has taken about a month.

- ☐ Apple Search Ads account set up before launch, with campaign structure: brand, generic, competitor and discovery.
- ☐ Meta event integration tested (Stage 4) and domain verification done.

Creative pipeline

- ☐ 20 to 30 hook variants generated cheaply first, then 5 to 8 winners shot by human creators.
- ☐ UGC-style, 15 to 30 seconds, captions on, no logo in the first 1.5 seconds, problem then demo then single call to action. UGC-style ads have reported lower cost per install than studio demos. [VERIFY] with your own tests.
- ☐ Three angles per app: problem-aware, comparison with the old way, and trust (no hidden subscription, cancel in a few taps). The trust angle is open in most categories we researched.
- ☐ New creative every week, since fatigue sets in within 7 to 10 days. A tagged creative library shows which hooks, angles and creators win.
- ☐ [GATE] Every ad claim reviewed against Stage 6: no unsupported accuracy claims, no medical claims, creators disclose paid relationships.

Organic and owned

- ☐ Landing page per app with privacy and terms, a Smart App Banner and email capture.
- ☐ Short-video accounts (TikTok, Reels, Shorts) posting before paid spend starts, to test hooks for free.
- ☐ Search-intent content for how-to queries in the category.
- ☐ Built-in sharing loops used where they fit (caregiver invites in baby and pet trackers).

Reputation

- ☐ Every negative review answered within 48 hours, and the most common complaint fixed and named in the release notes.
- ☐ No purchased, incentivized or support-steered reviews. Apple has removed hundreds of ratings from competitors for this.
- ☐ Review mining from the Phase 0 tool feeds product and creative decisions every week.

Stage 9: Launch

Days are counted from the planned release date (T). Apple's review time is the least predictable lead time, so treat T as a target and move the dates when the approval date moves.

T-30 to T-21: lead-time items

- ☐ Meta ad account submitted for approval (if not already) and Apple Search Ads account ready.
- ☐ Apple Developer organization account active and Paid Apps Agreement signed.
- ☐ Landing page, support email and policy pages live on the company domain.
- ☐ Creative briefs written for the three angles. Creator contracts signed, with disclosure terms.
- ☐ TestFlight internal testing running. Crash reporting and analytics confirmed on real builds.

T-21 to T-8: build, test and submit

- ☐ External TestFlight with at least 5 testers outside the team. Every reported crash and data-loss bug closed.
- ☐ ATT pre-prompt copy, paywall and cancellation flow approved by the founder on a real device.
- ☐ Per-app kill and scale numbers recorded (Stage 0).
- ☐ Privacy policy, terms and App Privacy labels reviewed by the lawyer. Name clearance complete.
- ☐ App Store listing complete and the build submitted for review, with reviewer notes and a demo account.
- ☐ Creative shot and the first 10 to 15 ad variants approved.

T-7 to T-1: readiness

- ☐ [GATE] No-go list is clear: no open crash or data-loss bug, a sandbox purchase, restore and cancel all pass, privacy documents are live, and attribution events show up in the ad platforms.
- ☐ Final regression test on a real device and the oldest supported iOS version.
- ☐ Support inbox staffed with reply templates for billing, cancellation, refund and data-deletion requests.

- ☐ Alerts live for crashes, payment webhooks and API cost. A rollback or hotfix path is agreed.
- ☐ Ads loaded and approved, but not yet spending.

Launch day

- ☐ Release manually. Download the live app from the App Store and run a real first-open-to-paywall pass.
- ☐ Confirm first-open, onboarding and paywall events arrive in analytics and in the ad platforms.
- ☐ Switch on a small first budget. Do not edit ad sets or Target CPA after they start learning.
- ☐ Watch crash-free rate and support inbox hourly for the first day. Reply to every review.

T+1 to T+7

- ☐ Daily review of installs, cost, install-to-trial, crashes and reviews against the dashboard.
- ☐ Hotfix any bug that touches payments, data or onboarding the same day.
- ☐ Rotate in new creative. Retire ads that fatigue.
- ☐ First day-7 retention read at T+7. Do not judge Apple Search Ads before two weeks or Meta before the learning phase ends.

T+8 to T+30

- ☐ Week-2 checkpoint against the kill criteria. Weeks 4 to 6 checkpoint on modeled LTV:CAC.
- ☐ First update shipped, fixing the top complaint from reviews and support.
- ☐ Decision recorded as scale, iterate or kill, with the numbers that drove it.
- ☐ Learnings written back into this playbook so the next app starts from them.

Stage 10: Post-launch operations

Unresponsive support and silent product decay were the most common complaints across the competitors we studied, so this stage is a differentiator, not overhead.

Support

- ☐ Reply to every message within 24 hours, and to billing, cancellation and deletion requests the same day where possible.

- ☐ Reply templates for: how to cancel (links to Apple's subscription settings), refunds (Apple processes IAP refunds; point users to Apple's report-a-problem page), data export, data deletion, and bug reports.
- ☐ Data-deletion and access requests completed within the 30-day internal target and logged.
- ☐ Support issues tagged by cause and reviewed weekly. The top three causes become the next release's fixes.

Release and maintenance cadence

- ☐ Update every 2 to 4 weeks in the first six months, with honest release notes that say what changed. Templated filler notes are a mark of neglected apps.
- ☐ Test every iOS beta from June and ship compatibility updates before the September release.
- ☐ Monthly: dependency updates, SDK inventory review, vulnerability alerts cleared.
- ☐ Quarterly: rotate API keys and secrets, test a database restore, review the privacy policy against what the app actually collects.
- ☐ Watch for changes to Apple's guidelines and Meta's ad policies, using the Phase 0 competitor tools plus the platforms' own announcements.

KPIs to review weekly, and the benchmark each is read against

KPI	Benchmark we measured against	Note
Install-to-trial	About 10.9% across categories (Adapty 2026)	Varies sharply by plan type
Trial-to-paid	About 48.8% for card-gated trials	Opt-in trials without a card were about 18%
First-renewal retention	Utilities 58%, Health & Fitness 30%	Choose the benchmark for the app's own category
Day-30 usage retention	Subscription apps about 14%; productivity and utility apps 10 to 18%	Usage retention differs from renewal retention
ATT opt-in	15 to 35%	Lower for utilities
Refund rate and crash-free sessions	Set per app after launch	Any spike triggers a same-day review

- ☐ [VERIFY] Benchmarks against current Adapty, RevenueCat and AppsFlyer reports each quarter, and replace them with the app's own history once it exists.
- ☐ Decision log kept per app: date, decision (scale, iterate, kill), the numbers behind it, and what was learned.

Churn and product learning

- ☐ Cancellation reason captured with one optional question inside the cancel flow. It is never a barrier.
- ☐ [VERIFY] Apple's win-back offer options for lapsed subscribers.
- ☐ Feature requests logged, but no new feature ships before the core activation and retention numbers are healthy.

Continuity

- ☐ Access list for every account (Apple, ad platforms, Firebase or Supabase, domain, payment services) kept in a password manager, with recovery codes stored securely and at least two people able to recover each account.
- ☐ Each app's spec, prompts and runbook live in its repo so work can be handed to another builder.

Sunsetting an app

- ☐ Criteria for retiring an app are set in Stage 0. If one is retired: stop ads, announce with notice, honor the paid period, offer data export, and keep support running until the last subscriber's term ends. One competitor shut down with a short export window and users were left with their history.

Stage 11: Finance and company operations

The whole portfolio runs on a \$100K reserve, so spending discipline is a product requirement. One modeled Fax test came to about \$47.5K, roughly half the reserve, and that model used estimated inputs. Full-size paid tests can run on only one or two apps at a time.

Budget and stop-loss

- ☐ [GATE] Total budget split into paid tests, tools and APIs, legal and accounting, stipends and a held-back buffer. The founder records each amount.
- ☐ Per-app test budget set from its Stage 0 model, with the model's inputs labeled measured or estimate.
- ☐ Stop-loss rule recorded. Starting proposal: commit no more than half the reserve to paid tests until one app clears the LTV:CAC gate, and pause all spend if cumulative test spend reaches that line without a winner.
- ☐ Spend tracked per app and per channel weekly, against the plan.

Cash flow

- ☐ Ad spend is paid before revenue arrives. Apple pays developers weeks after the fiscal month closes, so the plan models the gap. [VERIFY] Apple's current payment schedule.
- ☐ Meta ad account currency and time zone chosen deliberately at creation, since they generally cannot be changed later. [VERIFY]
- ☐ [VERIFY] With a chartered accountant: how foreign-currency receipts, ad-spend payments, and GST on advertising are handled for an Indian company.
- ☐ Forex fees on cards and transfers included in the cost model.

Books and compliance

- ☐ Separate company bank account and cards. Monthly bookkeeping close, reconciled against Apple's sales and payment reports and ad-platform invoices.
- ☐ A compliance calendar kept with the accountant: company filings, GST, TDS and advance tax. [VERIFY] all dates and obligations.

- ☐ Intern stipends paid on schedule, with formal offer letters issued once incorporation is complete.
- ☐ Cyber-liability and professional-liability insurance considered before the first paying users.

Vendor and account inventory

Tool or account	Purpose	Owner
Apple Developer Program	App distribution, in-app purchases, Search Ads attribution	Founder
Firebase (shared project)	Crash reporting and analytics for all apps	Kushagra to configure, founder owns billing
Firebase or Supabase (per app)	App backend	Builder of that app
Telnyx	Fax delivery for the fax app	Founder, used by Kushagra
Meta Ads and Apple Search Ads	Paid acquisition	Founder
Domain registrar and Google Workspace	Company domain and email	Founder
Ad research tools (for example AdWhispr Ads)	Competitor ad intelligence for Phase 0	Founder, used by Harshil

- ☐ Every row gains monthly cost, renewal date, and what user data the tool holds. The data column feeds the SDK and vendor review in Stage 3.

Fundraising readiness

- ☐ Per-app cohort tables, unit economics on net proceeds, and the decision log from Stage 10 kept current as a ready data room.
- ☐ IP assignments signed (Stage 6) and a clean record of who owns what.
- ☐ Plan to convert to a Delaware C-Corp if a US VC round happens. [VERIFY] the structure with counsel before that conversation starts.

Risk register

The two risks that could end the whole plan at once are the shared Apple account and a small reserve spread over too many apps. Review this table monthly and add a row after every incident.

Risk	Why it is real	Mitigation	Owner
Apple account terminated or flagged	One account holds all 12 apps; repeated sloppy or thin submissions are the pattern Apple watches	Submit only genuine builds, keep submissions clean, two admins, never manipulate reviews	Founder
Apps rejected as spam or template clones	Guideline 4.3 targets near-duplicate apps from one developer	Distinct UX, content and brand per app; review before submitting	Founder
Review or rating manipulation	Apple removed 297 ratings from a competitor, 73% of them five-star; one competitor's support allegedly steered users to post only positive reviews	System review prompt only, no gating, no incentives	Founder
Subscription-law exposure	A competitor was hit by an FTC action in June 2026 over billing; state auto-renewal laws are strict	Billing rules in Stage 2, 3-step cancel, lawyer review	Founder
Third-party SDK leaks user data	The FTC's Apitor case involved a third party collecting children's location	SDK inventory and review before every addition	Builder
Child or health data incident	Flo faced an FTC action and a \$59.5M settlement for sharing health data	Retention policy, encryption, no ad-network sharing, lawyer review before launch	Founder

Risk	Why it is real	Mitigation	Owner
Secret or API key leaked	A live API key was pasted into a chat during this project	Keys server-side only, secret scanning, same-day rotation on any exposure	Builder
A builder leaves or is unavailable	Three interns, four apps each, no shared code	Spec and prompts in each repo, access list, review by a second person	Founder
Contributors' IP not assigned to the company	Interns write all the code before incorporation completes	Signed IP assignment before any code is pushed	Founder
AI-generated code ships with gaps	Placeholder data, missing error paths and unbuilt deletion are typical	Review checklist in Stage 3, manual test script, TestFlight	Builder
Unit economics are worse than modeled	Most model inputs were estimates and used gross prices, not net proceeds	Label measured versus estimate, net out the store fee, measure on small spend first	Founder
Budget exhausted before a winner appears	A single modeled Fax test was about half the reserve	Stop-loss rule, 2 to 3 apps at a time, 15% per-app cap before a gate	Founder
Attribution loss from low ATT opt-in	Industry opt-in is only 15 to 35%	Apple Search Ads first, strong pre-prompt, conservative models	Founder
Ad account delayed or banned	Meta approval has taken about a month; policy violations can disable accounts	Apply early, compliant claims, keep a documented ad review step	Founder
History lost in apps that store user records	Recipe, sleep and pet apps in our research lost users' data	Durable saves, backups, tested restore, never lock history behind a paywall	Builder

Risk	Why it is real	Mitigation	Owner
Free platform feature replaces the category	Apple's free Measure app uses the same ARKit as paid competitors	Stage 0 free-alternative check	Founder
Name or trademark dispute	HelloFax already existed and most obvious names were taken	Clearance and attorney opinion before launch	Founder

Appendices

A. Decisions the founder still has to make

- ☐ Native framework: Swift/SwiftUI or React Native. Record the choice and the reason in Stage 3.
- ☐ Subscription or paywall service (RevenueCat, Superwall or none). A chat message mentioned "Supawall"; I assumed it meant Superwall, so please confirm.
- ☐ Mobile measurement partner or platform SDKs only.
- ☐ Which 2 to 3 apps receive paid spend first.
- ☐ Whether the Phase 1 list stands as is. Storage cleaner, Plant identifier, Baby tracker and Immigration tracker rank lower than the top picks on the LTV/CAC-weighted ranking, so the founder should confirm they are in for reasons the ranking does not capture.
- ☐ The shared review-gate component in the design kit: remove it or redesign it so it never filters who reaches the App Store (Stage 2).
- ☐ Merchant of record for any web billing. Paddle was considered earlier but is not confirmed.
- ☐ Meta ad account currency and time zone.
- ☐ Whether to keep all apps on one Apple account.

B. Needs a professional before launch

- US privacy lawyer: privacy policies and terms for all apps, children's and health-data rules, auto-renewal law, trademarks, breach plan.
- Employment or IP lawyer: contributor IP assignment and offer letters.
- Indian chartered accountant: tax forms for Apple, GST and foreign-currency receipts, tax on ad spend, filing calendar.
- Corporate counsel: the Delaware C-Corp conversion before any US VC round.

C. Templates

ATT pre-prompt, one sentence tied to a benefit already delivered. Trigger and copy per app; apps not listed define theirs before building onboarding.

App	Trigger (first value moment)	Suggested copy
Fax	After the first successful send	Allow tracking so we can show you fewer, more relevant ads and keep the app affordable.
Baby tracker	After the first logged entry	Allow tracking to help us keep the app free of clutter and focused on what matters to your family.
Sleep tracker	After the first completed sleep session	Allow tracking so we can tailor sleep insights to you and keep the app free to start.
TV remote	After the first successful control action	Allow tracking to help us keep the app ad-supported and free.
Document scanner	After the first scan or export	Allow tracking so we can keep the app free and show you relevant offers.
Calorie counter	After the first logged meal	Allow tracking to personalize your nutrition experience and keep the app free.

Reviewer-notes template for App Store submission:

How to reach each feature: <screen path for every main feature>
 Demo account: <email> / <password> (or: no login required)
 Paywall: Settings > Upgrade. Sandbox purchases are enabled.
 Permissions: <camera / location / photos> are used only to <specific purpose>.
 Subscription terms are shown on the paywall, with Terms and Privacy links.
 Contact: <name, email, phone>

Cancellation copy, three screens with identical labels throughout:

1. Your plan and renewal date. Buttons: Keep my plan, Continue to cancel.
2. What happens next and the exact end date, with at most one offer. Buttons of equal size: Take the offer, No thanks, cancel anyway.

3. Final confirmation and, for Apple subscriptions, a button that opens Apple's subscription settings.

D. Status of the facts in this playbook

Benchmarks and rules here come from research earlier in this project: Adapty's 2026 subscription benchmarks, Meta and Apple Search Ads documentation and third-party summaries of it, FTC and state-law summaries, and the competitor teardowns. They are named but not linked, and several Apple and Meta rules change often. Everything marked [VERIFY] should be checked against the current official page, and any figure used in a decision should be replaced by the app's own measured data as soon as it exists.